A Homeland Across the Atlantic

Three Argentine-born siblings between Argentina and Germany, 1938–1948

Virginia Vecchioli



When an imagined homeland

becomes a place to leave

What can one family's journey from

Argentina to Germany and back tell us

about what it meant to be German

before, during, and after the Second

World War?

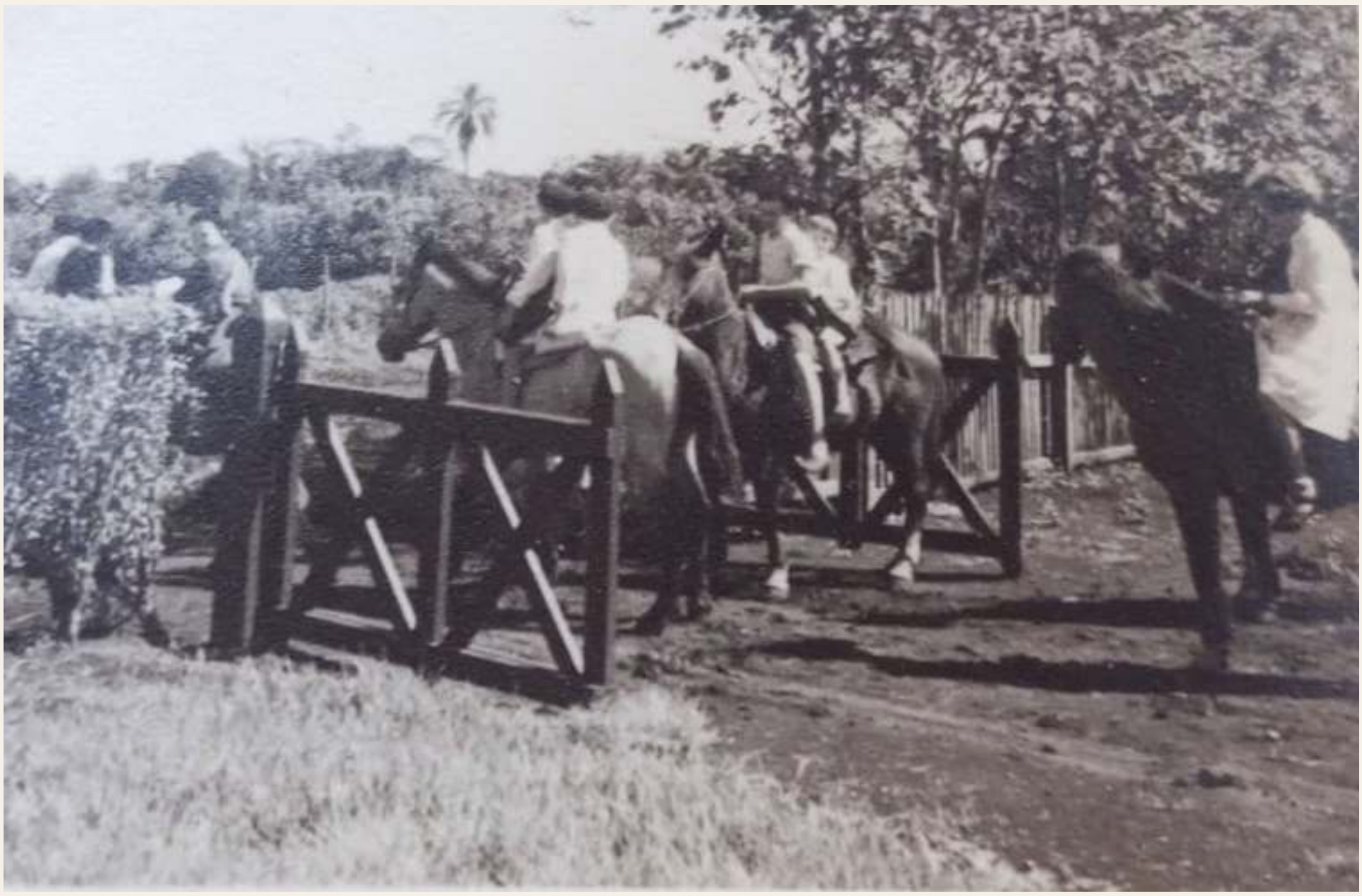
The story begins far from Germany



Map: Alberto Carlos Muello. Peuser. 1930

Misiones, in northeastern Argentina, borders Brazil and Paraguay and lies more than 13,000 km from Germany

Germany as an imagined homeland



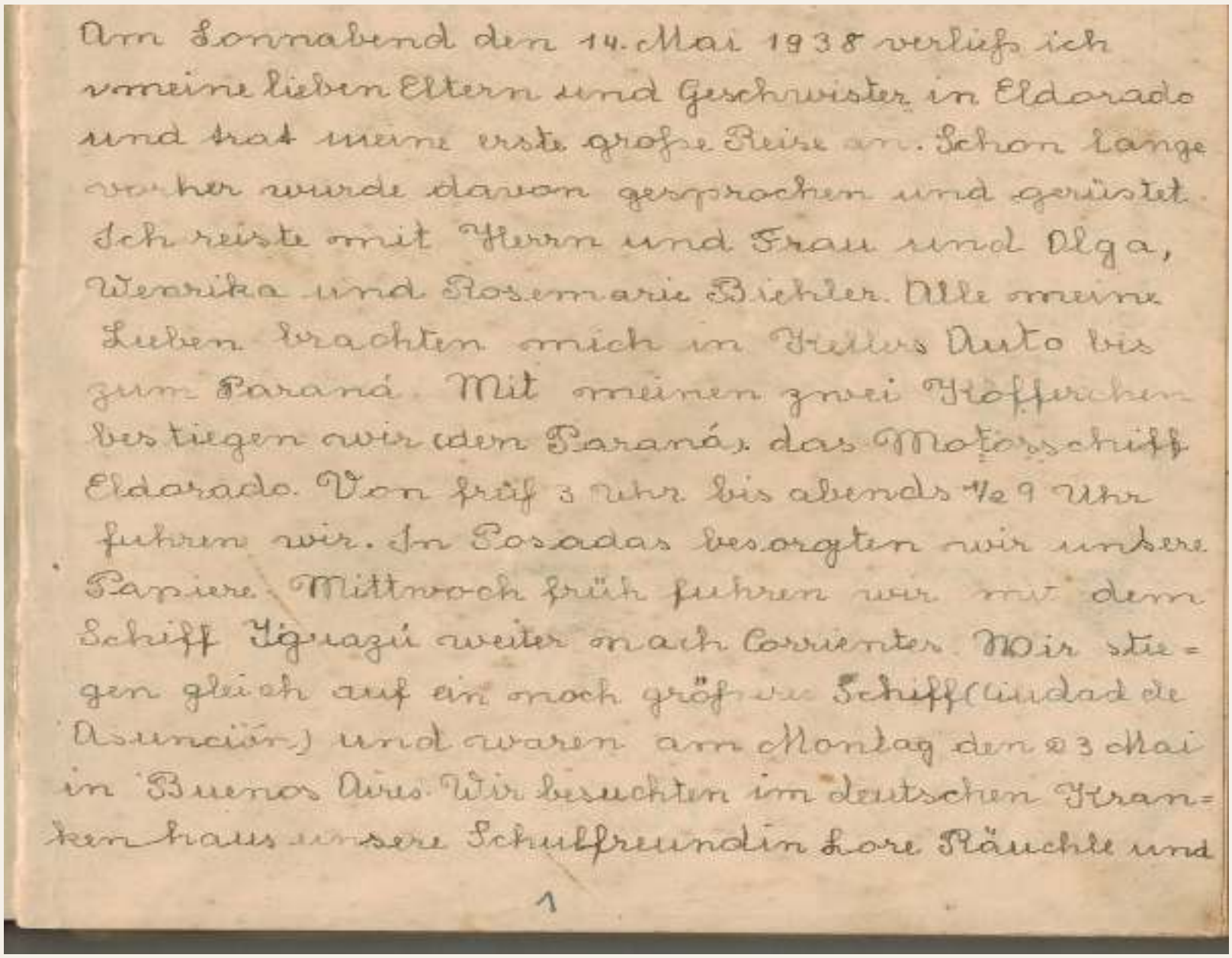
The four siblings on their way to their German school
Family archive

The siblings were born in Misiones to German-born parents who migrate to Argentina in 1924.

Yet Germany was present in family life, language, education and ideas of belonging

1938: Across the Atlantic

Argentina to Germany



Am Sonnabend den 14. Mai 1938 verließ ich meine lieben Eltern und Geschwister in Eldorado und trat meine erste große Reise an. Schon lange vorher wurde davon gesprochen und gerüstet. Ich reiste mit Herrn und Frau und Olga, Wenzika und Rosemarie Bichler. Alle meine Lieben brachten mich in Heller's Auto bis zum Paraná. Mit meinen zwei Köfferchen bestiegen wir den Paraná: das Motorschiff Eldorado. Von früh 3 Uhr bis abends ½ 9 Uhr fuhren wir. In Posadas besorgten wir unsere Papiere. Mittwoch früh fuhren wir mit dem Schiff Iguazú weiter nach Corrientes. Wir stiegen gleich auf ein noch größeres Schiff (Ciudad de Asunción) und waren am Montag den 23 Mai in Buenos Aires. Wir besuchten im deutschen Krankenhaus unsere Schulfreundin Lore Räuchle und

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First page from Ruth's diary . Family Archive

Ruth's diary records an Atlantic crossing that lasted just over a month. One sister remained in Argentina.

Her two brothers joined her in 1939, just fifteen days before the outbreak of war

A “fairy tale” homeland



Ruth with a relative in Germany.
Family Archive

When Ruth arrived in Germany, relatives were waiting for her at the port, together with members of the Bund Deutscher Mädel, the National Socialist youth organization for girls.

“*they shouted a warm welcome to us and sang happy cheerful songs”* Ruth's diary
For Ruth, arriving in Germany felt like entering a *“fairy tale”*

Homeland
at the outbrake of the war



Landfrauenschule Arvedshof in Elbisbach, Saxony. Family archive

According to her daughter, Ruth attended this rural training school for young women.

Historical records indicates that Arvedshof was affiliated with the Reichsnährstand from 1933.

The Reifensteiner school network was subsequently subjected to National Socialist institutional and educational control.
Source: Liste der Reifensteiner Schulen. Wikimedia

1939: A generation drawn into war



A cigarette-card postcard depicting members of the Hitler Youth, sent to their parents in Argentina. Family archive

Günter, Ruth's brother, described his time in Germany in his memoirs as "*the most difficult time of my life*"

The brothers arrived in Germany at ages 10 and 12. They attended schools and took part in youth organizations shaped by the National Socialist system. In his memoirs, one of the brothers recalled being recruited for the Reichsarbeitsdienst (Reich Labor Service) and later into the SS at the age of 17. They were sent to the front and became prisoners of Soviet forces during one year and a half.

Leaving Germany was not simple



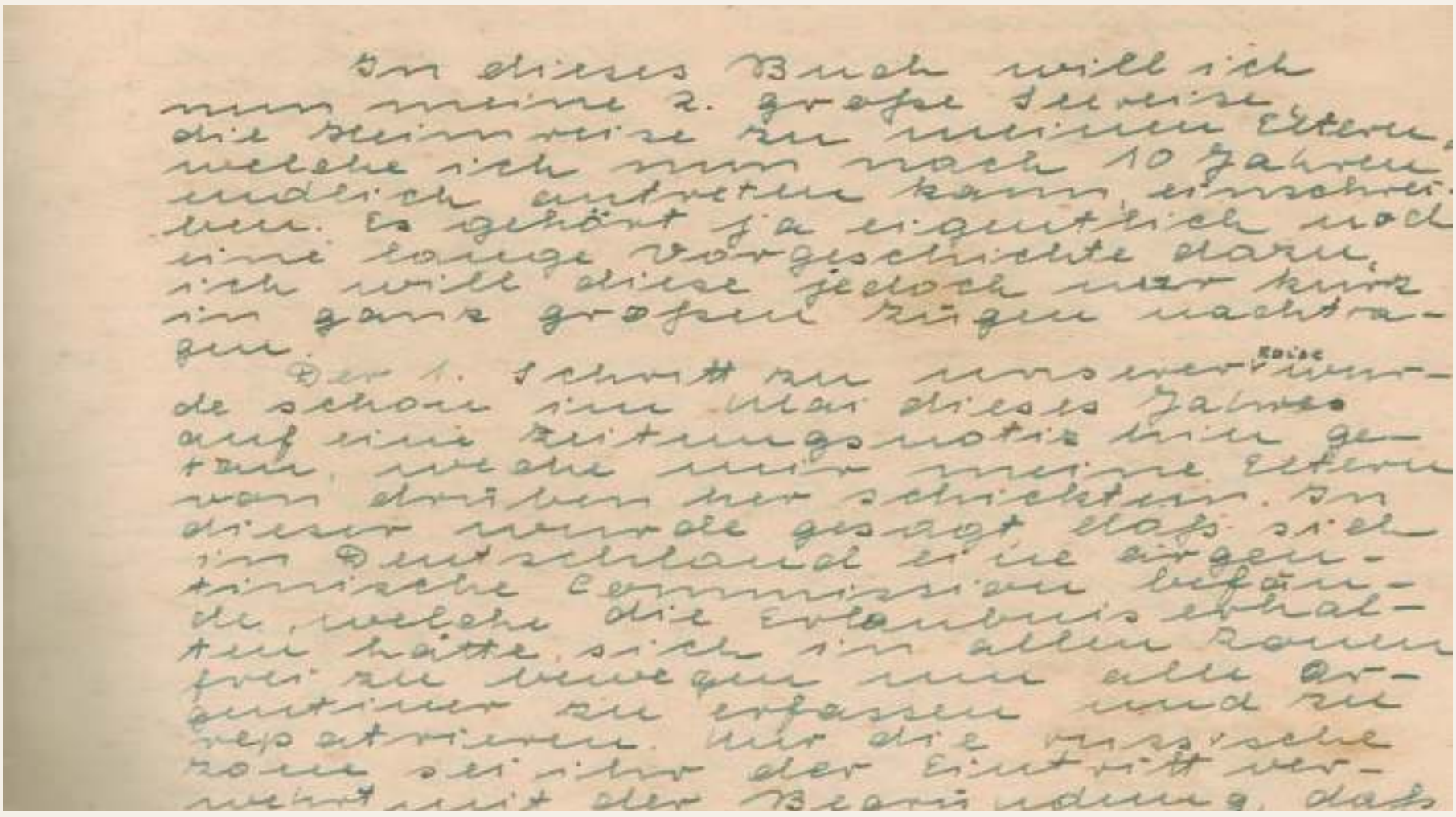
Ship Córdoba: Compañía Argentina de Navegación Dodero

The war interrupted the siblings educational plans in Germany. After the defeat and the brothers' captivity, returning to Argentina was not immediate.

Before they could leave, they had to navigate the postwar system and obtain denazification certificates.

According to Ruth's diary, the siblings returned to Argentina aboard the Córdoba

The journey home

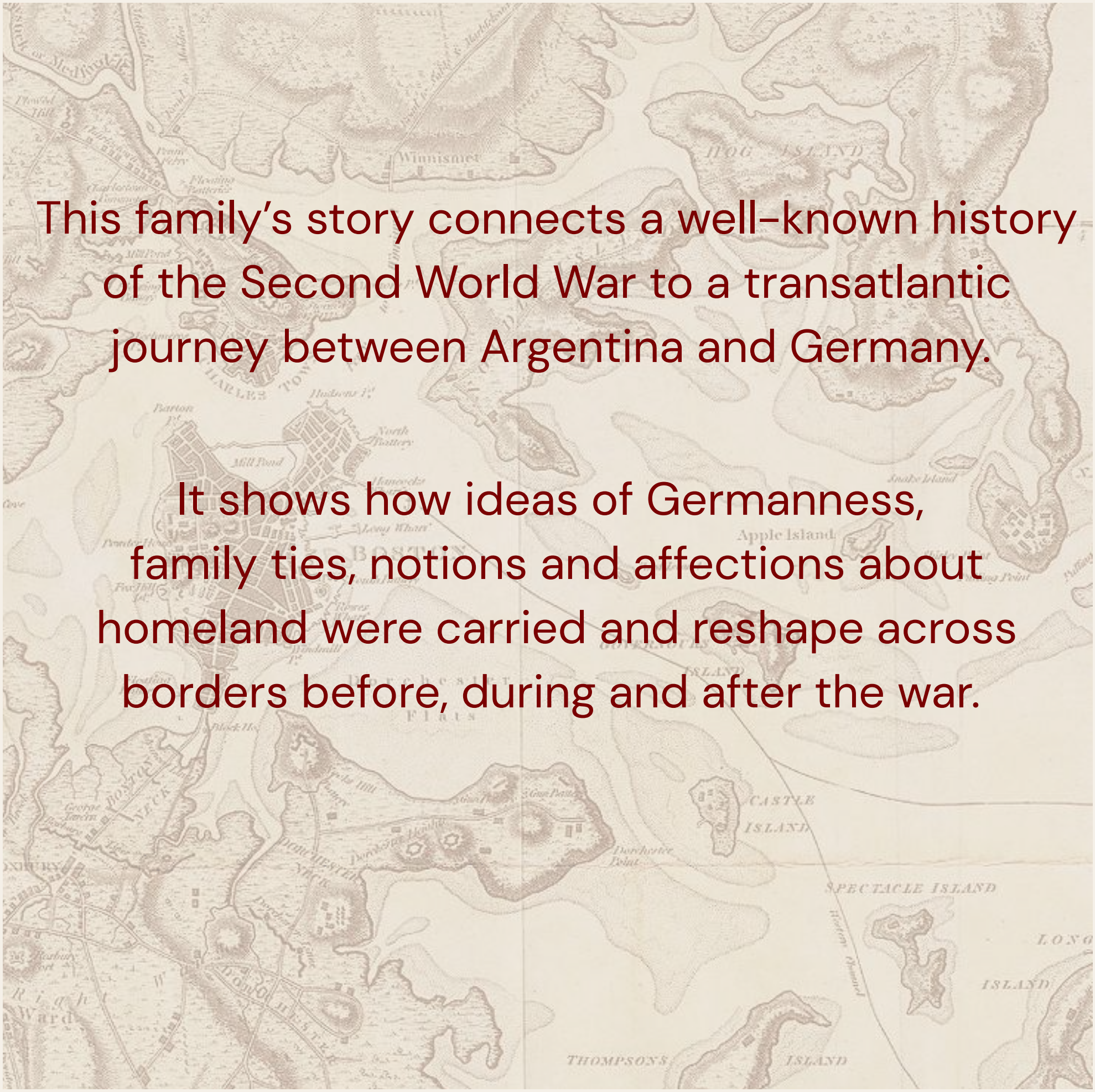


A page from Ruth’s diary documenting her return 18 Dezember 1947

“In this book, I wish to record my second great voyage,
the journey home to my parents”
“No one was standing at the harbor waving goodbye;
only the police were standing guard.
Thus, our farewell to Germany took place
in complete silence; everyone was lost
in their own thoughts.”

Ruth's diary

Homeland redefined



This family's story connects a well-known history of the Second World War to a transatlantic journey between Argentina and Germany.

It shows how ideas of Germanness, family ties, notions and affections about homeland were carried and reshape across borders before, during and after the war.

Homeland redefined

For these siblings, “homeland” was not a fixed place.
Its meaning changed through migration,
war and return.
Its traces remain part of family memories
across the Atlantic today.



The port through which the siblings left Argentina and later returned.
Photograph by Virginia Vecchioli, fieldwork, 2024

Acknowledgements

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CREATED BY
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PRIVACY NOTE
To respect the family's privacy, surnames and the specific name of the German-speaking colony in Misiones have been omitted.

AI USE
CHAT GPT assistance was used for English translation and language editing and providing technical guidance during the visual design process with CANVA